A STUDY OF DANCE AS A PRAGMATIC SYSTEM OF COMMUNICATION WITH REFERENCE TO TAGORE'S *TASHER DESH*

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CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that this dissertation entitled "**A STUDY OF DANCE AS A PRAGMATIC SYSTEM OF COMMUNICATION WITH REFERENCE TO TAGORE'S *TASHER DESH***" is a record of research work done by **SREYOSHI BASU**, a full-time student of **MADRAS CHRISTIAN COLLEGE**, doing her **MASTER OF ARTS IN ENGLISH LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE, DEPARTMENT OF ENGLISH**, during the period 2019 – 2021. The dissertation represents an entirely independent work on the part of the candidate under the supervision and guidance of **Dr. S. FRANKLIN DANIEL**, Associate Professor, Department of English, Madras Christian College (Autonomous) Chennai.

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DECLARATION

I hereby declare that this dissertation titled "**A STUDY OF DANCE AS A PRAGMATIC SYSTEM OF COMMUNICATION WITH REFERENCE TO TAGORE'S *TASHER DESH***" for the degree of Master of Arts in English Language and Literature is a record of research work done by me, under the guidance and supervision of **Dr. S. FRANKLIN DANIEL**, Associate Professor, Department of English, Madras Christian College (Autonomous) Chennai, during the period 2019 – 2021.

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ABSTRACT

Pragmatics is a sub-genre of linguistics that, in contrast to Semantics, studies the implied meaning of various forms of communication. Dance, like any language, is capable of semanticity owing to its inherent structures and specific codes which are derived from the representation and imitation of objects and emotions. For instance, the mudras in Bharatanatyam can be used to depict the blooming of a flower. However, the communication of meaning in dance is not limited to such literal, referential portrayals and can be largely allusive and connotative in its nature. This dissertation will be a study of dance as a pragmatic system of communication by focusing primarily on the performative aspects of pragmatics that manifest through body language, movement and facial expression. It will center around the argument that a pragmatic approach to analyzing the "meaning-bearing" capacity of dance provides a broader scope for effective communication of meaning. The significance of the pragmatic features of dance will be established through an analysis of the representation of the theme of oppression versus freedom of expression in Rabindranath Tagore's satirical dance-drama *Tasher Desh - The Land of Cards*.

Keywords: Pragmatics, semantics, dance, Tagore, communication, body language, expression

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

Human beings have been captivated by the art of dance for millennia. Today, dance has established itself as an essential expression of culture. This thesis explores the concept of dance as a potent non-verbal medium of communication. It has been shown that dance makes use of inherent structures that are similar to those used in verbal language, regardless of the difference in the channel of communication. Dance, like verbal language, exhibits a distinction between its semantic and pragmatic modes, and this forms the basis of the analysis. The research will center around the argument that a pragmatic approach to analyzing the "meaning-bearing" (Bannerman 77) capacity of dance provides a broader scope for effective communication of meaning. The significance of pragmatic features becomes evident in the foregrounding of the theme of oppression versus freedom of expression in Rabindranath Tagore's satirical dance-drama *Tasher Desh* (*The Land of Cards*).

The sole objective of any form of communication is the effective transmission of meaning. Semantics is a sub-discipline of linguistics that refers to the systematic structure consisting of specific codes employed in every system of communication to enable users to convey literal meaning. Meaning is studied at the level of individual words as well as the meanings that result from their combination in sentences. It "consists of conventional rules of meaning for expressions and their modes of combination." Sentence meaning is defined as the "compositional meaning of the sentence as constructed out of the meanings of its component lexemes" (Riemer 41). However, successful communication of meaning is reliant upon much more than just these basic structures. In the case of verbal language, "more is involved in what one communicates than what one literally says; more is involved in what one means than the standard, conventional meaning of the words one uses" (Korta and Perry para 1, 7).

Pragmatics is a field of study that focuses on these ancillary elements of language that supplement its literal meanings. In contrast to the literal meanings of its code, pragmatics offers insight into the intended meaning of the user. The meaning conveyed in a sentence composed of its individual meaningful components is quite often significantly different from the actual meaning it has within a specific context. Conversations generally "use words and expressions ironically, metaphorically, insincerely, and in other 'non-literal' ways." Hence, in contrast to sentence meaning, utterance meaning foregrounds the function of context in imparting additional layers of meaning to a sentence (Riemer 21). Therefore, the subject matter of pragmatics is concerned with "how meaning is produced and understood in context" (Hornsby 198).

Herbert Paul Grice emphasises the "distinction between what someone says and what someone 'implicates' by uttering a sentence." What the speaker says is associated with the literal content of the utterance, whereas its implicature, is connected with the non-literal: "what is (intentionally) communicated, but not said" (Korta and Perry para 22). Conversational implicatures are functional under the common understanding that all forms of meaningful communication follow a co-operative principle that relies on the "speaker's shared knowledge and experience." Grice suggests that all successful communication is achieved by adhering to four general maxims of conversation, namely quality, quantity, relevance and manner, where all involved parties are in cooperation. Nonetheless, it has been noted that these maxims are often and overtly violated without leading to the breakdown of conversation. In such cases, the interactant does not "merely violate the maxim concerned, [but] does so ostentatiously and thereby actively sends a signal to an interlocutor that co-operation is, in fact, being maintained at a deeper level" (Hornsby 200, 209). This deliberate infringement is known as a maxim flout and aids in disclosing the underlying implicatures of the conversation.

The significance of pragmatics in any medium of communication is often underestimated. Nina F. Dronker and others contend that,

> The tendency to treat pragmatics as an extension or attachment to the traditional functions of linguistics has obscured its independent reality in human interactions, the important role it plays in what could be called "nonverbal social communication". Even without the benefits of semantics or syntax, a great deal of social interaction is still possible. Pragmatics could be a window onto these important competencies. (181)

According to Tim Wharton (1), "sentences are rarely uttered in a behavioural vacuum. We colour and flavour our speech with a variety of natural vocal, facial and bodily gestures, which indicate our internal state by conveying attitudes to the propositions we express or information about our emotions or feelings." In the words of Erving Goffman, a "wagging tongue. . . proves to be only one part of a complex human act whose meaning must also be sought in the movement of the eyebrows and hand" (qtd. in Wharton 1). Therefore, "it's up to semantics to tell us what someone literally says when they use expressions of a given type; it's up to pragmatics to explain the information one conveys, and the actions one performs, in or by saying something."

Non-verbal elements of communication are an essential component of pragmatics. These include extralinguistic features such as body language, gaze, hand gestures, and facial expression which help to communicate information that extends beyond the literal, semantic meanings of words. In the absence of a verbal language, these non-verbal elements support the entire weight of communication. Human beings often depend upon this innate ability to communicate through the use of their body. Dance, as a performance art that communicates exclusively through the body, can be considered an extreme manifestation of this ability. Since

a dancer's primary instrument is their body, this study aims to understand how these extralinguistic aspects of pragmatics might be used to effectively convey meaning through dance.

To examine the ability of dance to effectively express meaning, this thesis will first analyse its internal structures in order to understand its semantic potential. In other words, using examples from Indian classical dance forms like Bharatanatyam, the basic structures found in dance will be studied for their capacity for semanticity. Most dance forms across the world have systematically codified arrangements of movement and gestures. These are recorded in notations and scores for future reference and provide the framework for its style. These form the basic framework for expression, but do not encompass the entire essence of the meaning communicated. Similar to verbal language, communication of meaning in dance is not limited to the representation of simple literal, referential meaning. This emphasises the importance of adopting a pragmatic approach to comprehending the complete potential of dance communication.

Acknowledging the deficiency of a semantic analysis of dance, this thesis will attempt to examine the pragmatic dimensions of dance. The context, culture, the dancer’s intuition and the audience’s perception all play an important role in the comprehension of meaning through the medium of dance. These factors influence the usage of body language, facial expression, space and gesture to a large extent and result in the unveiling of multiple layers of meaning. A pragmatic approach to the understanding meaning conveyed through dance has remained relatively unexplored. Theories by eminent dance scholars like Joseph Margolis, Julie C. Van Camp, Judith Lynn Hanna and others attempt to locate the essence of meaning in dance outside its semantic structure and hence, suggest that pragmatic features play an important role in communication through the medium of dance.

A master craftsman of words, Rabindranath Tagore brought his ideas to life using dance, music, poetry and drama. He was a pioneer in establishing a modern aesthetic for Indian dance within which he integrated a wide variety of influences. Dance became an important medium for the expression of his creative vision. Tagore incorporated dance within his drama's in order to enhance the depiction of their themes. As embodied expressions, his themes became visually articulated and had an evident effect upon the audience. Four of his most popular dance-dramas classified under the title 'Rabindra Nritya Natya' are *Chandalika*, *Chitrangada*, *Shyama* and *Shrabangatha.* Each one of these is revolutionary in terms of defying numerous dominant stereotypes relating to gender, nationalism, and social beliefs.

Tagore's famous dance-drama *Tasher Desh* is a socio-political satire that is presented using a vibrant setting of fantasy. First performed in 1933 in Kolkata, it tells the tale of a sterile, lifeless society that rejects its totalitarian rules and embraces liberation. The coercive forces of oppression stifle every form of self-expression resulting in the inhabitants identifying themselves as two-dimensional cards. Dance becomes a crucial element in foregrounding the theme of oppression versus freedom of expression. Using the English translation by Radha Chakravarty, *The Land of Cards*, this thesis will analyse the role of dance in enhancing the meaning of the play. It will also explore the significance of pragmatic features of dance in facilitating the overall communication of meaning in the drama. Ultimately, this study aims to foreground the relevance of pragmatics in the effective communication of meaning.

CHAPTER TWO

DANCE AS A SEMANTIC SYSTEM OF COMMUNICATION

Among the many performance arts, dance is an integral aspect of every culture across the world. It contributes significantly to the domains of religion, ethnic identity, gender marking, education and socio-political organization (Hanna 491). John Dewey and Eliot Eisner foreground the immense scope contained in dance for the "expression of agency, creativity, lived experience, transcendence, learning through the body and the power of the arts to engender visions of alternative possibilities in culture, politics and the environment" (qtd. in Hanna 491).

Prior to the establishment of verbal languages, the body was a primary instrument utilized by human beings for their basic communicative needs. Different parts of the body were combined to form gestures that could be used to represent situational and abstract concepts. They first learned to recognize the clues provided by the body and then comprehend meaning in them. Many inner states of feeling are seen to have outward manifestations through the body (Arnold 62).

In the absence of a verbal language, the body and its gestures fulfil all the requirements of communication, by employing a "word-and-sentence-level structure" (Hanna 495). Susan Goldin-Meadow and Heidi Feldman, observing the behaviour of deaf subjects lacking any prior access to "explicit, conventional language models," noticed that they were naturally inclined towards developing a "structured communication system" using body gestures demonstrating both lexicon and ordered semantic relations. The subjects were able to develop two types of the lexicon: "deictic signs," which used pointing gestures (such as "this" and "there") to refer to objects and people in the present, and "characterising signs," which used motor-iconicity to relate to referents based on apparent physical similarity to portray actions, such as flapping

hands to indicate the act of flying. In addition to referential lexicon, the subjects "concatenated their deictic and characterizing signs into multisign phrases that conveyed relations between objects and actions," thus exhibiting features of syntax and semantics. (401 - 403).

Dance augments this innate ability in human beings to express emotions and communicate through gestures and movement. The communication of meaning in dance is independent of verbal cues and manifest purely through non-verbal modes such as gesture, proxemics, body contact, posture, body orientation, facial expression and gaze. (Graddol et al.147). "Drawing from movement in everyday life, dance stylizes movement with a degree of conventionality or distinctiveness" (Hanna 495). As George Lakoff and Mark Johnson elucidate,

> Concepts arise from, and are understood through, the body, the brain, and experience in the world. Concepts get their meaning through embodiment, especially via perceptual and motor capacities. Directly embodied concepts include basic-level concepts, spatial-relations concepts, bodily action concepts (e.g., hand movement), aspect (that is, the general structure of actions and events), colour, and others. (qtd. in Hanna 494)

This attests to the statement by Clement Crisp and Edward Thorpe that, "mankind has always danced" (qtd. in Rounds 1).

The important role of gestures in communication reflects upon the exponential capacity of dance to convey meaning because it "utilizes a multi-channelled gestural system to communicate: gestures of various body parts, and locomotion in time, space, and with effort, music, and costume. . .that can convey declarative, procedural, and emotional knowledge." Dance, then, as conceptualized by Judith Lynne Hanna is, "purposeful, intentionally

rhythmical, and culturally influenced sequences of nonverbal body movements and stillness in time and space and with effort" (Hanna 492-495).

The locus of meaning may be found in the structure, style, actions, or in the use of specific techniques (Hanna 493-497). John Blacking recognizes that there are,

> Coherent, structured languages of dance, and that the transfer from verbal to non-verbal discourse constitutes the core of the dance experience. It is not that people abandon reason for emotion when they dance, but that they often introduce another argument, whose grammar (see p. 9) and content are most effectively, though not exclusively, expressed in non-verbal language. (93)

Every form of dance comprises unique implicit structures that constitute the foundation of its style. These structures, primarily derived from the representation and imitation of objects and emotions, provide the rudimentary means for communication of meaning. Following the principles of Plato and Aristotle, Western dance aesthetics considers the concept of "representation" in dance to mean *mimesis*, which translates to imitation in English. Sally Banes and Noel Carroll identify different types of representation such as "unconditional representation" where the audience use certain cultural codes to recognize the referent, and "lexical representation" in which specific gestures indicate certain ideas. **(**Bresnahan para 40)

Henrietta Bannerman (68) suggests that the presence of a code-based system within all dance forms indicates that dance is structured like a language. Bannerman expounds that, "dance genres such as classical ballet or South Asian dance feature sophisticated codes of mime which convey ideas on a similar basis to the words of a language in that they obey their own interlinguistic rules."

The structural elements found in dance use organizing principles that are comparable to those of grammar in language. Even though the channels of communication are different,

where verbal language is dominated by "the vocal, auditory and somewhat static visual channels," dance utilizes the "motor, moving, visual and kinesthetic channel…," the comparison persists because the relation between structure and meaning in dance can be paralleled with syntax and semantics in language (Hanna 494; Smyth 20). Similar to the function of vocabulary, the well-defined structures in dance provide a basic methodology for the communication of meaning during a performance.

For instance, Indian classical dance forms like Bharatanatyam display dance vocabulary in its codified sequences of movement known as *adavus.* Performed in the specific posture called *aramandi* along with hand gestures known as *mudras*, these function both as mimetic representation and aesthetic ornamentation and can be used independently or in combination (Bharatanatyam Mudras para 7, Nandanam para 6). For example, the mudra *alapadma* depicts the blooming of a lotus.



Examples of Bharatanatyam Mudras
https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-981-15-2043-3_22

"Dance is a form of stylised movement that bears some similarities to verbal language" (Hanna 493). Dance and verbal language display inherent usage of vocabulary and syntax. Even though ascribing definite meaning to movement is significantly more difficult than it is in language, "vocabulary and syntax are present in dance in the way that the word vocabulary is often employed to describe the selection of specific movements, and syntax, to represent the combination of arrangement of those movements (vocabulary) into chains or phrases of dance material" (Bannerman 66).

Vocabulary in dance provides the basic units of construction in a choreographic design. Valerie Preston-Dunlop defines dance vocabulary as a "set of artistic or stylistic forms or techniques." They are comprised of "specialist codes" of mimetic gestures, definite sequences of movement and locomotion that can be organised in varied combinations for the purpose of the performance. (Bannerman 70, 77). Both dance and verbal language have vocabulary (locomotion and gestures and dance).

In 1976, Nelson Goodman classified dance as an "allographic" art, contrasting it to an "autographic" one (see p.21). According to him, the distinctive characteristic of an allographic art form is that its works can, "in identification-relevant form, be notated," as opposed to the "autographic" forms which consist of a "stable and singular art object that is tied to a particular history of production" (Bresnahan para 14). He admits that "a score need not capture all the subtlety and complexity of a performance," however, its purpose "is to specify the essential properties a performance must have to belong to the work…" (qtd. in Bresnahan para 14)

Bharata's *Natyasastra* documents the first attempt to systematically codify dance vocabulary in written text. After the emancipation of dance from traditional drama, a new category called *nrytya* ("mimetic dance") was established. The fourth chapter of the *Natyasastra* provides technically detailed instructions on 108 basic units of dance known as

karanas (Sanskrit for "doing"). "The *karana* is. . .formed by a union of three main components, namely a bodily posture (*sthana*), a foot movement (*cari*) and a hand gesture for dance (*nrttahasta*)." Abhinavagupta's *Abhinavabharati*, an 11th-century commentary on the *Natyasastra*, emphasizes the representational function of the *karanas* (Ganser 152).

Syntax in a language corresponds to the specific rules of organizing vocabulary. The ingrained framework in the practices of different dance forms instructs the systematic arrangement of dance vocabulary and gives dance its syntactical nature. Syntax in dance consists of rules that justify the organization of one movement after the other. Just as "verbal language strings together sequences of words. . .dance strings together sequences of movement" (Hanna 493). The order in which one movement follows the other is of considerable importance. Every dance form has its own syntactical rules that dictate minute details of how movements are to be performed. For example, in certain Bharatanatyam movement sequences, if one step finishes on the right leg, the next step must, by default, begin with the left; a double-step, in this case, would be considered ungrammatical. Additionally, as Henrietta Bannerman writes, "the order in which the movements are performed have the effect of altering meaning." She further exemplifies that,

> A phrase or a movement in a western dance context comprising an arabesque combined with running steps and jetes (jumps) invokes or suggests ideas such as flight or emotions like joy and ecstasy. Similarly, a run, jump and fall may change its effect on the viewer if the order is reversed in that the first syntactical ordering suggests elation followed by disappointment and the second version counteracted by optimism. Radical alteration in the delivery of accepted forms of dance syntax, challenge expectations and achieve the effect of surprise for the viewer. (70)

Similarly, the *Natyasastra* contains records of certain permissible methods of combining and performing the *karanas*. “According to dance Masters, the movements of the feet [should] conform appropriately to the hand movements [used] in the [*karana*]” (qtd. in Ganser 154). Abhinavagupta, by allowing the use of hand gestures along with the *karanas*, believed that they could be arranged in different combinations and positions to represent sentences portraying varied emotional states like jealousy and anger.

The presence of vocabulary and syntax in dance aid in the representation of literal, imitative meaning. Additionally, dance notation records the basic guidelines for the particular usage of movement in a dance piece in written format. Its function, according to Nelson Goodman is to “specify the essential properties of a performance” (Bresnahan para 5). Following the Natyasastra, the *Abhinayadarpana* by Nandikesvara is an authoritative treatise on contemporary Indian dance practices. Consisting of 324 verses, it documents the codification of imitative movement (Ganser 156). Therefore, dance exhibits a dependence on definite associative ties with things and situations as resources for its “meaning-bearing capacity.” (Bannerman 77).

Despite the existence of immense diversity in the forms of dance, every dance performance consists of a meaningful transaction between the performer and the audience. Jack Anderson describes dance as “movement that has been organized so that it is rewarding to behold” (qtd. in Smyth 19). Dance is a medium of “purposeful communication” (Hanna 492) in which movements are methodically designed to evoke the desired emotions in the audience. The process of ascribing meaning to movements is an act of “conscious human intention” (Blacking 93). The communication of desired meaning occurs in the intentional act of performing choreographed sequences of movement in an artistic way. The dancer becomes the “expresser of meanings” by literally embodying it (Arnold 66). Hence, communication through the medium of dance is mostly premeditated.

John Blacking (93) observes that the feelings and ideas expressed or received via the medium of dance are "drawn from a repertoire of collective sentiments. . ." In *What Is Dance? Readings in Theory and Criticism,* Susan K. Langer (33) writes that dance performances only portray imagined feelings and not real emotional states. "Dance gesture is not real gesture, but virtual" and therefore, it only creates a "semblance of self-expression without anchoring it in the actual personality." Hence, the emotions expressed during a dance are predetermined to suit the requirements of the performance. This demonstrates that a dancer "expresses the emotion symbolically, creating an illusion of the emotion rather than feeling its actual presence" (Hanna 597). Explicating further on the "virtual gesture," Langer writes that,

> In the dance, the actual and virtual aspects of gesture are mingled in complex ways. The movements, of course, are actual; they spring from an intention, and are in this sense actual gestures; but they are not the gestures they seem to be, because they seem to spring from feeling, as indeed they do not. The dancer's actual gestures are used to create a semblance of self-expression, and are thereby transformed into virtual spontaneous movement, or virtual gesture. (Langer 33)

Linguistic codes are associated with meaning based on purely arbitrary relations. As Charles Hockett expounds, "there is no similarity between the sound of the word and its sight, sound or smell," and the signifier doesn't inherently contain the meaning of its signified. Hence, linguistic exchanges depend upon the users' familiarity with the code-based system of representation within the language. Despite, mimetic structures in dance, this arbitrary relation between words and their meanings in language can also be found in dance. Similarly, audiences and choreographers perceive meaning in movement-based upon their existing knowledge of their usage as they "become accustomed to the correlation between movement and meaning and also to codes that operate within choreographic practices" (qtd. in Bannerman 68).

Nevertheless, dance continues to be a potent, non-verbal means of communication that expresses varied narratives of genuine human conditions. Eminent American choreographer Paul Taylor once said, “I make dances in an effort to communicate to people. A visual medium can be more effective than words. I make dances because I don’t always trust my own words or, for that matter, those of quite a few others I’ve known” (qtd. in Hanna 495). The literal, representational nature of communication allowed by its structures attests that dance is a semantic system.

However, as seen in language, semanticity does not encompass the entire essence of conveyed meaning. “The linguistically encoded logical form. . .is simply a starting point for rich inferential processes. . .” (Wharton 9). Similarly, the efforts to “correlate movements and distinct expression notationally” and present meaning encoded in literal representative structures prove to be insufficient and unconvincing (Margolis 419). The comprehension of meaning in dance is not limited to a “factual form of artistic expression,” and is a more allusive and implicative phenomenon (Bannerman 65).

CHAPTER THREE

DANCE AS A PRAGMATIC SYSTEM OF COMMUNICATION

A system of communication that is supported solely by its semantic structures is inadequate. The literal meaning of words does not capture the entire essence of a conversation, and comprehension of meaning is attributed largely to other ancillary cues. Herbert Paul Grice, in his theory of conversational implicatures, observes a distinction between the meaning of words and their implication. The meaning is often seen to reside within the literal content of the words, whereas their implicature identifies with the non-literal aspects. Pragmatics is a field that focuses on these additional elements that supplement literal meaning. By studying not what is said, but how it is said, it entails "perception augmented by some species of 'ampliative' inference. . ." (Korta and Perry para 8). The process of conveying implied meaning, in the words of Jill House, rests in "the 'packaging' rather than the 'content' of the message" (Wharton 9).

Pragmatic abilities encompass non-verbal communication skills that emphasize the non-literal elements of speech that are intended but not articulated by the speaker (Djordjevic et al. 9; Korta and Perry). Nikola Rot foregrounds the importance of paralinguistic and extra-linguistic aspects in non-verbal communication (qtd. in Djordjevic et al. 3). The extra-linguistic cues consist of kinesics and proxemics, which correspond to the reliance on body language, eye contact, gestures and distancing as fundamental units of communication (Smyth 9). These carry the potential to "communicate some response or information concerning the emotion, attitude or state of being, though perhaps not in the same way that conventional gestures are used" (Key 17).

Pragmatic meaning is sometimes comprehended through words that remain unsaid. The effective communication of meaning depends more on extra-linguistic cues than on actual

verbal codes. They bring out the "specific manifestations of meanings [that are] supposedly hidden by words" (Key 29). A correlation between the verbal and non-verbal elements can "alter the salience of linguistically possible interpretations" (Wharton 3). For example, They can either work in *accordance* or *contradiction.* As Mary Ritchie Key explicates,

> Nonverbal Acts which are in accordance with the speech act or other behaviour situation enhance and contribute to the communication in a harmonious way. There is no disagreement of message and delivery. In contradictory behaviours, on the other hand, there is a discrepancy between the words and the real feelings held by the speaker and this disharmony shows up in the paralinguistic and kinesic acts. (28)

Research by Goldin-Meadow and others suggests that "when speech and gesture convey different information, gesture carries the dominant message" (Hanna 495). Similarly, the pragmatic features of dance contain the potential to enhance or revert the meaning of its semantic structures. A certain arrangement of steps performed with an openness of the body, joyful facial expressions and a lively gaze would indicate that the dancer is expressing a happy emotion. On the contrary, the same arrangement of steps combined with a crouching body language, anguished expression and restricted body movements would change the meaning perceived by the audience entirely.

Dance is a non-verbal system of communication that manifests entirely through these extralinguistic aspects. The ancillary elements of verbal communication become the main source of expression in dance. Alan Radley views dance as an art form that can illuminate the "elusory" expressive power of body movements (Nyström and Lauritzen 300).

Graddol et al in *Describing Language* (119), expound a distinction between 'sentence meaning', which corresponds to "the words and the syntax of what is said" and 'utterance

meaning', which "takes account of other features of the linguistic context (such as intonation) and situational context." Henrietta Bannerman (77) proposes that movement in dance resembles the production of an utterance rather than a sentence. Therefore in order to reveal the implied intricacies of a choreography, "ancillary or contextual elements. . .are required." This indicates that the efficacy of meaning transmission through the medium of dance depends upon multiple pragmatic features.

Comprehension of meaning in dance is a "two-phased process" (Wharton 9) that transcends the scope of a systematic code-based system. Even though, underlying semantic structures resembling vocabulary, syntax in verbal language are found, dance as a nonverbal art form is not tied down to literal factual representations. As stated by Henrietta Bannerman, "the syntactical ordering of the movement material must be bolstered by mime and/or gestural action as well as being viewed in relation to whatever framing devices are involved such as narrative context, music, costume, scenography, lighting and state properties" (Bannerman 66, 70).

In dance, meaning comprehended simply using its "complex logical structures" produces a deficient outcome, as it omits layers of signification that lie beyond the scope of these structures. Although there exist elaborate notation systems that describe physical movement, there is "no tool to probe for meaning in dance," (Hanna 493, 502) because dance, in its essence, is a form of expression that reflects the human soul and cannot be entirely encapsulated in definite, logical notations and structures. As Joseph Margolis (421) states, "there simply is no reliable correspondence between a dancer's performing a set of movements in accord with a mere notation and an audience's seizing the expressive qualities somehow conveyed by those movements." Judith Mackrell opines that with "dance movement alone it is not possible to 'analyse […] argue [or] contextualise" (Bannerman 77).

The perception of meaning in dance is highly inferential and connotative in nature. Dance expresses both mimetic and abstract behaviour. With its extreme sense of openness, it resembles poetry with its multiple, symbolic and elusive meanings (Bannerman 69, Hanna 493). As elaborated by Judith Lynne Hanna,

> Dance is multisensory, and so it heightens the perceptual awareness that expands access to the meaning of different kinds of emotional expressions. There is the sight of dancers moving in time and space; the sound of physical movement, breathing, accompanying music and talk; the smell of dancers physical exertion; the tactile sensation of body parts touching the ground, other body parts, people or props, and the air around the dancers; the proxemic sense of distance among dancers and between dancers and audience; and the kinesthetic experience and sense of empathy with a performer's bodily movement and energy. The eyes indicate degrees of attentiveness and arousal, influence attitude change, and regulate interaction. (492)

Julie C. Van Camp proposes a pragmatic approach to discovering the "identity" of an art form. In her views, a pragmatic perspective rejects essentialism, which is "a method of identifying fixed and unchanging features of a given concept" (Bresnahan 19), celebrates pluralistic conclusions thereby recognizing "the validity of multiple points of view, multiple histories, or, in sum, multiple world representations," emphasizes on everyday experiences and recognizes divergent communities in the art world.

According to Peter J. Arnold, the role of a dancer is much more than that of a "mere formulator and transmitter of a simple message." A lot depends upon their "interpretive and expressive powers to reveal what the dance is about and how best to present its potential emotional content." With the creative use of style, imagination and technique, "new shades,

levels, and subtleties of meaning emerge and become intelligible to the audience" (Arnold 65, 66) thus portraying pluralistic tendencies.

The process of discerning the pragmatic nuances of non-verbal communication is fundamentally linked to its context. Ray Birdwhistell, a pioneer in the study of kinesics, observes that "the body movement cannot be separated from the person who performs the movement, or from the where and when in the wider context of the interaction." Hence, the interpretation of meaning in body movement has to take into consideration the individuals interaction with others within a wider cultural context. (Djordjevic et al. 300).

The movements of dance gain multiple layers of signification depending upon the context they are performed in. A dance becomes meaningful in the context that is specifically designed for it. This is achieved using music, lighting, costumes, stage properties and backdrops that facilitate a meaningful transmission between the performer and the audience.

Culture plays an important role in determining the context of the performance. As David Best observes, "there is an inseparable interdependence between artistic meaning and the life of a society" (qtd. in Arnold 62). Hence, "culture. . .refers to the values, beliefs, norms, and rules shared by a group and learned through communication... [it] gives meaning to who dances what, why, how, when, where, and with and for whom, in addition to the role of the dance audience" (Hanna 492).

Different sets of meaning can be perceived in dance based on the different cultural and social contexts they operate in (Blacking 95). Bharata's *Natyasastra* does not attribute specific hand gestures to each *karana*. This is because the interpretation of their meanings varies significantly when used in different contexts (Ganser 153). The meaning of dance movements alters based on the context they are used in. Therefore, the context attributes meaning to the dance movements and guides the identification of its significant units. John Blacking (95)

asserts that “the structures of dance and the purposes to which they are put must therefore be analysed in context, together with dancers’ and spectators notions of what they are doing, what they experience, and how they make sense of it.”

J. L Austin’s pragmatic theory necessitates that the performative act be executed only by qualified persons in appropriate contexts. Likewise, Abhinavagupta doesn’t consent to the arbitrary usage of the *karanas.* Taking the example of the *karana* ‘apaviddha’ which is said to represent a sage, he contends that “it would be an error to employ this *karana* in the context of a character different from the authorized ones” (Ganser 154). This demonstrates that the representative function of the *karanas* is extensively connected to the context in which it is used.

Despite the fact that dance is highly reliant on its semantic structures to communicate meaning, audience members who do not possess any prior knowledge of these structures are still capable of interpreting the ideas and emotions that it conveys. This indicates that there are other pragmatic factors of communication in operation alongside the semantic ones. The gestures, expressions and movements portrayed in dance derive a lot from everyday human communication and are grounded in common “social facts” (Blacking 95). Awareness of these attributes of communication enables the audience to comprehend the meaning communicated through dance.

James categorized bodily postures into four basic kinds and designated them as “approach, withdrawal, expansion, contraction”. As summarized by Mary Ritchie Key,

> *Approach* conveyed such things as attention, interest, scrutiny, and curiosity. *Withdrawal* involved a drawing back or turning away and indicated negation, refusal, repulsion, and disgust. *Expansion* referred to the expanded chest, erect trunk and head, and raised shoulders, which conveyed pride, conceit, arrogance,

> disdain, mastery, self-esteem. *Contraction* was characterized by forward trunk, bowed head, drooping shoulder, and sunken chest. The figure shrinks, shrivels, cringes, cowers, crouches, droops, and thus indicates that the individual is depressed, abased, downcast, dejected, crestfallen. (22)

He recognised "the coordinating relation of facial expression, gestures and bodily posture" and asserted that they be considered a "unit of the function of expression." (Key 22). When used in different positions and combinations, they result in varied emotional outcomes. By correlating their awareness of these social gestures to dance movements, audience members can comprehend meaning in dance without knowledge of its basic structures. A shared understanding within "a culture's social practices" makes meaningful discourse in dance possible (Van Camp 46).

The reader-response theory focuses on the requirement of the reader in bringing a text into existence. Similarly, Janet Adshead-Lansdale foregrounds the crucial role of the audience in interpreting the meaning of a given dance performance. The audience member is no longer a mere spectator who passively consumes the performance but becomes an active agent in contributing to its perceived meaning. According to Richard Shusterman, the audience member helps to "create and determine the qualities and meanings of the work of art rather than merely revealing them" (Adshead-Lansdale 17). Research on communication suggests that meaning "is understood as a joint construction in the sense that all participants contribute to the communicative process and its meaning" (Nyström and Lauritzen 300). In this scenario, the audience members "are performers no less than dancers, just as readers participate in the works they read and each reading adds to the work", the audience imparts multiple layers of meaning to the dance based on their interpretation of its pragmatic features.

Most modern dance practices "eschew the idea that dance can be reduced to or compared to anything like a score or text" (Bresnahan para 5). Joseph Margolis (419) recognizes that notational guidance and the semantic structures of dance are insufficient in capturing the true essence of meaning communicated through dance. He argues that "dance scores are primarily heuristic devices for recovering a minimal sense of the principal positions and movements of a given dance. . ." Explaining further, he states that "there is no sense in which the perception of related positions and movements, ordered perhaps in an interesting way and legible from the notation itself, could possibly be grounded in an understanding of the deeper structures of the dance."

Mark Franko, observes that "contemporary thought on dance is frequently split between a concept of dance-as-writing and a concept of dance as beyond the grasp of all language, especially written language" (Bresnahan para 5). In "The Autographic Nature of the Dance," Margolis disagrees with Nelson Goodman and categorizes dance as an "autographic" art form. He proposes a theory which contends that an effective artistic transaction between the dancer and the audience occurs due to the "natural expressiveness" which is "intrinsic to the movement of the human body" (Sirridge and Armelagos 301). Explicating further on his theory, he writes that,

> The dancer does not work with simple positions and movements, but with the naturally expressive use of positions and movements generated (not altogether consciously) by that person's use of his own body through accumulated grooming of a continuous life; and, imposed on, and altering, this natural and acquired expressiveness, individuated through an exclusively privileged experience with a single body, the dancer learns the expressive possibilities of different styles and the way in which his own performing body, stylistically informed, is viewed by knowledgeable observers. (Margolis 421)

The expressive quality of dance then, “maximizes [on] improvisational forms and the recognition of stylistic congruence within actual performance” and “is noticeably easily lost in performances guided solely by the notation of correct positions and movements” (Margolis 425).

In recent times, dance as an art form has undergone major changes. The emerging trends allow for more freedom and have paved the way for the new concept of “open form” which provides “alternatives to repetition according to present structures.” which are no longer sufficient. Improvisation is a crucial technique that facilitates the “overthrow of hierarchical structures and the endorsement of open form.” Improvisation derives from the “intuitive resources of the mind and body” and helps in the discovery of new meanings that the systematic preconceived structure does not convey. The human body and its interaction with other bodies is the primary instrument through which improvisation occurs. According to Curtis L. Carter, “the full range of human attributes, including the physical, conceptual, and emotional resources embodied in the body are available for improvisation in dance. (Carter 181, 182)

A significant type of improvisation observed by Carter (182) is the “embellishments left to the individual artists where set choreography persists.” This allows the dancer to amplify and enhance existing movements, such as the incorporation of an additional stylistic flourish. This aspect of dance can be paralleled with the “embellishing type” of extra-linguistic behaviour, which serves to “eloquently enhance speech.” The embellishing type of body language “invites response and attention to the Communication act” (Key 23). As stated by Mary Ritchie Key (23), “without the embellishing types of body language, speech would be dull and unattractive.”

An example of such embellishments can be observed in the use of the *rechaka* in Indian dance. A *rechaka* is a “subtle nuance that connects every part of the *karana*, thus giving it

seamless fluidity" (Karanas Decoded 10.58 : 11.05). In the *Natyasastra*, Bharata mentions four types of *rechaka* of the feet, waist, shoulders and neck (11.42 : 11.59). These enhance the communicative function of the *karanas* and make the movements seem less mechanical. Consequently, the movements not only appear more aesthetically pleasing, but the fluidity of the movements provide the dancer with the freedom to augment their expressions (see chapter 4).

Communication of ideas and feelings through dance is not easily verbalizable (Smyth 20). Maurice Merleau-Ponty asserts that "we understand each other in a more immediate way at a bodily level" (qtd. in Nyström and Lauritzen 313). Therefore, tacit knowledge which cannot be articulated verbally can be expressed kinesthetically and emotionally through dance (Hanna 496). Consequently, Jack Anderson contends that "…dance communicates because it prompts responses within us. Dance is not simply a visual art, it is kinesthetic as well; it appeals to our inherent sense of motion" (Smyth 19).

An important aspect of non-verbal communication through dance is the use of space, rhythm and effort to produce synchrony. Rhythmical synchrony refers to "a simultaneous sharing of rhythm with any part of the body" and can be pivotal in the establishment of a connection between the performer and spectator for successful transmission of meaning (Nyström and Lauritzen 300). By occurring within an intense, dynamic ambience, it can "induce emotion through energetic physical activity or through the interaction between dancers or between dancers and spectators."

The theory of dance as a kinesthetic form of communication suggests that a meaningful transaction between the performer and audience occurs due to the dancers' acute sensation of their movements which subsequently evokes "bodily responses" in the audience watching the performance. Research by Barbara Montero reports that audience members admit to feeling

kinesthetic responses “such as a quickening heart rate and certain tensions along with more mysterious feelings in their muscles and nervous systems” (Bresnahan para 57).

The interpretation of meaning in dance is multifarious. As a performative art, it encompasses “the possibility of multiple instances of the ‘same work’” (Arnold 65). Taking into consideration that the human body is the “principal instrument” used for the purpose of communication, the art form admits a wider variation in its performances (Van Camp 3). Dance utilizes “salient bodily aspects” which makes it difficult to comprehend the connection between the mind and the body in the “making, performing, evaluating and appreciating of dances.” (Bresnahan para 5).

A significant amount of meaning deciphered from the movements in dance depends upon pragmatic features. The multiple theories that attempt to determine the source of meaning in dance attest to the fact that meaning transcends the limitations of a semantic structure. Especially in the case of dance-theatre, dance provides the necessary support that enables the audience to perceive its intricate, underlying significations.

CHAPTER FOUR

ANALYSIS OF THE SIGNIFICANCE OF DANCE IN TAGORE'S *TASHER DESH*

Rabindranath Tagore's vision encompassed the entire gamut of human emotion and experience. His artistic endeavours were rooted in his desire to advance his humanistic worldview. Creativity, individuality and connection, in his opinion, were integral to creating a better world and improving the quality of life. He vehemently opposed authoritarian institutions that sought to stifle the vibrant spirit of mankind and induce a degeneration of the mind. He believed that "the mind is nourished in truth; the imagination is nourished in art, and the world of relationship is nourished in the sympathy for the created universe" (qtd. in Lal 33). The distinctive quality of his work is the display of an exceptional union of inspiration from all over the world. Lubna Marium observes that Tagore assimilated "the conventional with the avant-garde, the known with the unknown, yet remained quintessentially true to his own spirit" (qtd. in Chakraborty 368).

A "profound nostalgia for freedom and emancipation" pervades Tagore's literary output. Deeply concerned about the dehumanising totalitarianism within the country's political scenario, Tagore wrote extensively to invoke an awakening in the minds of his readers against the numbness propagated by the coercive regime. He advocated for the role of education in fostering self-reliance and human dignity. (Chatterjee and Banerjee 64, 65). Expressing his views, Tagore wrote,

> Whenever I realize the hypnotic hold which this gigantic system of cold-blooded repression has taken on the minds of our people whose social body it has so completely entwined in its endless coils that the free expression of manhood even under the direst necessity has become almost an impossibility.

> The only remedy that suggests itself to me and which even at the risk of uttering a truism I cannot but repeat, is – to educate them out of their trance. (qtd. in Gupta 103)

The school in Shantiniketan called Vishwabharati integrated alternate values of education, foregrounding creativity, humanity and individual choice in order to refresh the minds of the younger generation from the dogmas of an oppressive political climate. (Gupta 103) "Dance became an integral part of university education at Shantiniketan. . ." (Purkayastha 70) and enabled Tagore to create embodied presentations of his ideas.

Tagore engendered a unique, new and non-conformist approach to dance. Manjusri Chaki-Sircar explains that "the dance culture inspired by Tagore not merely represents [an] era of 'vibrant creativity' but also a 'breakthrough in the modernization of the Indian dance scene'" (qtd. in Chakraborty 364). He developed his own modern dance aesthetic by combining various Indian dance forms like Manipuri, Bharatanatyam, Kathakali, folk and martial arts. His extensive travelling also enabled him to incorporate western and South-Asian into his dance technique. As Prarthana Purkayastha (73) elucidates, his open-minded view prompted him to consider "dance not simply as beautiful or pleasing movement but as a kind of language." Tagore acknowledged and orchestrated the "dancing body as a medium for communication of ideas, concepts and narratives, and envision[ed] the dancing body as purveyor of history. . ." (73).

Describing his innovative style to dance in "Indian Modernity and Tagore's Dance," Mandakranta Bose writes,

> Rabindranath Tagore's invention of an entirely new dance style liberated dance from the formulaic choreography and narratives of classical Indian dance. Tagore advocated naturalistic rather than stylized expression, with the stated

> purpose of creating an aesthetic vehicle for conveying the drama of human emotional experience. This style, Rabindra-nritya, the first 'modern dance' of India, was and has remained entirely uncodified, relying on the creative impulse of the individual dancer interpreting poetical compositions. (Abstract).

Tagore's insistence on the role of human intuition, imagination, and free will in the creation of dance routines resonates with Joseph Margolis' theory of "natural expressiveness." The choreographers and dancers have the liberty to experiment and every performance of the dance drama is an opportunity for artists to adapt their subjective understanding of the themes into the choreography. The uncodified nature of Tagore's dances allow an immense scope for improvisation and creative interpretation, hence, resulting in a vivid variety of presentations.

Dance became a crucial component of his dramas and aided in accentuating his themes. Employing "modern tools", Tagore dismantled every stereotype to openly discuss themes of nationalism, gender and social equality. His revolutionary dance-dramas *Chitrangada*, *Chandalika* and *Shyama* foreground "the transgressive and radical bodies of the outcaste, the non-Hindu courtesans and the masculinized princess, reclaiming them from peripheral terrains of the nation" (Chakraborty 364).

Tagore's celebrated dance-drama *Tasher Desh* is a socio-political satire. It chronicles the exploits of a sprightly young prince who, tired of the stifling comfort and monotony of his own land, he exclaims, "We are fenced in with falsehoods. Languishing in the cage of safety, our wings have grown stiff" (Land of Cards 78). Hence, journeying abroad to seek freedom and adventure, he chances upon The Land of Cards, "a sterile society governed strictly by listless conventions and lifeless rules." With the rigid imposition of rules, the inhabitants of the land are "stripped of all sense of self and instead identify themselves as playing cards" Finding the inhabitants devoid of any sense of liberty or individuality, the prince challenges the

oppressive forces of control and strives to inspire a revolution among the card-people. Loosely inspired by Lewis Carroll's *Alice in Wonderland*, *Tasher Desh* creates a unique fantasy setting, that sustains "the drama of emancipation from social stagnation" (Banerjee 138). "The lavish and colourful costumes, as well as song-and-dance sequences, mainly brought out the cheerful and vibrant way in which the fantasy world in the play unfolded its serious connotations" (Chaudhuri 170).



Tagore with the cast of Tasher Desh
https://in.pinterest.com/pin/205124958007465454/

In *Tasher Desh*, dance becomes a medium to "physically illustrate" (Rounds 8) the theme of oppression versus freedom of expression. The philosophy Tagore used in developing his dance aesthetic reveals itself profoundly in the choreographic design of the play. Here, the prince, as an instigator of revolution, becomes the embodiment of freedom and the "metaphor of the cards encapsulates the sterility of this society" (Bhattacharjee; Purkayastha 78). The dance movement used by the card-people in the play is excessively systematic. As indicated in the play, their movements are extremely mechanical and strictly conform to the following rules,

Up and down,

Forward, Backward,

Left and right,

We do not glance,

Open and shut,

A topsy-turvy

Crooked deal,

That's all! That's it! (87,88)

They are seen to unquestioningly adhere to the rules imposed upon them. When asked to explain the purpose behind such restricted movements, the character Six responds, "Meaning? What use is meaning? We want rules," (88) signifying the severe extent of indoctrination. Despite being perfectly synchronised, the movements are devoid of character and emotion, and hence, utterly meaningless. Their coordinated movements and unhesitating compliance to the rules is indicative of a society devoid of expression, free will, inquiry and exploration. The movements of dance portraying a "living lifelessness" of the Cards reveals "a

petty, sectarian and artificial way of living in a stagnated society anywhere, and ridicules the tendency to fossilize human minds" (Gupta 103).



The restricted movement of the card-people in *Tasher Desh*
https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/entertainment/articleshow/69198935.cms

In contrast to the stiffness of the cards, the prince's dance movements are uninhibited, energetic, and vibrant. The card-people immediately recognize the prince as a foreigner in their land because of the difference in his body language. The prince extolls the values of liberty and the freedom to be self-expressive is integral to his character (Purkayastha 78). His "passionate, enthusiastic and frenzied nature" (Chatterjee and Banerjee 65) becomes immediately apparent in his free, unrestricted dance movements which allow him to be expressive of his views. In every stage adaptation of *Tasher Desh*, the prince's dance movements are choreographed with leaps, fluidity, the use of open arms, and space.

With brilliant enthusiasm and vigour, the prince strives to invoke a desire for freedom in the card-people in order to "set [their] captive spirits free" (Chatterjee and Banerjee 123). Slowly the system is unmade and transformation occurs among the card-people as they shed "their playing card identities and their totalitarian principles" (Purkayastha 78) and begin to emerge as humans. "The incipient transition from the dormant state to the awareness of a thrilling human living – pulsating with joys and sorrows of passion – is dramatized through various stages of response," of which the change is body language is the most significant" (Banerjee 139).

Dance becomes crucial in displaying this transformation as it manifests entirely through a change in the body language of the cards. Dance research illustrates that "changes of movement can bring about changes of feeling" (Blacking 98). This overt violation of the rules that dictate the behaviour and mannerisms of the Cards' is an illustration of a maxim flout. Breaking free of the stringent hold of the rules, the card-people are finally allowed the freedom to explore the deeper meanings of experience and life. This transformation that is projected using dance is a testament to Tagore's vision of dance. Prarthana Purkayastha remarks that the modern dance aesthetic of Tagore was "a conscious and critical engagement of dance with the political and social domains, where the dancing body is sometimes directly engaged with social protest" (qtd. in Chakraborty 364).

Tagore believed that "the creative spirit of the artist was indistinguishable from the creativity apparent in everyday aspect of life" (Lal 33). "Tagore's portrayal of the human conditions are intricately bound up with the complex relations within society" (Bagchi 45). This justifies the supreme lack of creativity in The Land of Cards. Creativity and individuality cannot flourish in a society devoid of the spirit of inquiry or discovery, that insists on the rigid imposition of laws. The context plays a huge role in dictating the type of body movement that is created within it. As Ray Birdwhistell explains, "the body movement is thus to be interpreted

as an expression of the individual in interaction with others and within the wider cultural context" (qtd. in Nyström and Lauritzen 300). A totalitarian society with passive inhabitants can only generate mechanical movements. On the other hand, the body's natural expressiveness is on display when there is freedom. The deliberate rejection of the stiffness induced by the rules of society by the card-people demonstrates a subversion of its prevailing choreographic semantics within the given context. This subsequently enables the exploration of the deeper implications of the free and fluid movements.

The dichotomy between the codified movements of the cards and the intuitive movements of the prince can be paralleled with the semantics versus pragmatics debate. The body language of the card-people is rigid and passive, while the freedom in the prince's body language fosters his individual expression. The excessively codified movements of the cards hinder the communication of emotions and ideas. Comparing the systematic movements of the card-people to the implicit structures of a dance, it can be understood that a semantic system, while providing the framework for dance movement, does not carry the entire brunt of effective communication. Therefore, dance as a pragmatic system provides a much broader scope for individualized communication.

CHAPTER FIVE

CONCLUSION

The purpose of this thesis was to explore the potential contained in the art of dance to be an effective medium of communication. The study centered upon the distinction between the semantic structures and pragmatic features of dance. The research indicates that, while the semantic structures provide a framework for conveying meaning, the real essence of the communication can be found in the pragmatic features which broaden the scope of the limited structures. A pragmatic approach allows more opportunity for the expression of an intuitive, creative and emotional interpretation of the choreography. An analysis of Rabindranath Tagore's celebrated dance-drama *Tasher Desh* (*The Land of Cards*) reinforces the importance of the role of pragmatics in communication through the medium of dance.

Despite the rich diversity in the forms of dance across the world, each form uses unique, codified structures that provide the guiding principle for its style. These structures are mostly formed through the imitation of emotions and objects. Henrietta Bannerman (68) contends that dance, like language, also utilizes a code-based system. An example of this can be found in the codified gestures and movements known as *mudras* and *adavus* used in Indian classical dance forms like Bharatanatyam. These can be used both independently or in combination for the purpose of mimetic representation or simple aesthetic ornamentation.

The basic structures of dance use an organization principle similar to that of verbal language by displaying traits of vocabulary and syntax. Dance vocabulary refers to a selection of specific movements (Bannerman 66). These are "specialist codes" consisting of mimetic gestures and definite movements that form the basic units of construction in a choreography (70, 77). This characteristic of dance allows for the systematic codification of dance

movements in notations and scores. The *Natyasastra*, *Abhinavabharati* and *Abhinayadarpana* are substantial Indian dance treatises that enumerate the specific vocabulary of dance.

Resembling the specific arrangement of words in verbal language, dance movements also occur in particular codified sequences. Syntax in dance corresponds to the specific combinations of arrangement of dance vocabulary. The organization of these movements in dance usually pertain to certain rules that determine their order of occurrence. According to Bannerman (70), a change in the sequence of movements can result in an alteration of the meaning conveyed. The *Natyasastra* describes the appropriate techniques of combining and performing dance vocabulary to portray varied states of emotion and meaning (Ganser 154).

This ability in dance to convey literal, referential meaning owing to the presence of vocabulary and syntax confirms the semanticity of dance. These semantic structures attest to the "meaning-bearing" capacity in dance and thus establish it as a viable medium of communication (Bannerman 77). However, a semantic approach to studying the meaning of dance movements is limited to simple imitative representations. Joseph Margolis (419) argues that a direct correlation between structured movement and meaning is inadequate and unconvincing. Dance uses a far more implicative way of portraying meaning and therefore, effective communication through dance cannot be restricted to its basic semantic framework.

On the other hand, a pragmatic approach to communication through dance takes into account the ancillary cues that enhance and supplement its literal, semantic meaning. As an exclusively non-verbal medium of communication, dance uses body language, gaze, facial expressions, gestures and space as its primary instruments to convey meaning. Beyond the codified techniques of using the body, the creative employment of these features determines to a large extent the type of meaning and emotion conveyed. The dancer brings out "specific manifestations of meaning" (Key 29) that are not contained within the semantic structures. This

indicates the presence of pragmatic factors in the process of communication through dance. Peter J. Arnold foregrounds the significance of dancers' creativity, imagination, and technique in bringing out different layers of meaning contained in the movement.

The ancillary and contextual elements provided by pragmatics are significant in revealing the implied intricacies of a choreographic design. The use of pragmatic features in dance can work in accordance to enhance the semantic meaning or work in contradiction to revert it. Dance, with its multi-channelled gestures, has the potential to express both mimetic and inferential meaning. The connotative and allusive nature of dance is foregrounded in Julie C. Van Camp's theory which rejects essentialism, celebrates the plurality of meaning and emphasizes everyday experience and the role of community in supplementing meaning in dance.

The pragmatic nuances of communication through dance are inextricably connected to the context of their occurrence. Ray Birdwhistell emphasizes that the movement of the body cannot be isolated from the context in which the interaction occurs. In the case of dance, the context is usually specifically designed for the performance with the help of lighting, music, backdrop, and costumes. The context provides multiple shades of signification to the movements of dance. The culture to which the dance form belongs also contributes towards making dance more meaningful. Culture and context also play a significant role in forming the source of the audience's prior knowledge and informing the perception of meaning in the dance movements. John Blacking (95) maintains that, "the feelings which people express or receive through the medium of dance are drawn from a repertoire of collective sentiments as much as from personal experience, and that people learn ways of talking about feelings as well as discover ways of acting them out." Therefore, the analysis of the structures of dance in its social and cultural context reveals multiple layers of meaning in its movements.

Contemporary practices of dance reject the notion that meaning communication in dance can be condensed into systematic notations and scores. Unlike the highly codified classical forms of dance, modern dance forms advocate for more freedom of movement in choreography, thereby giving rise to the trends like open form and improvisation. These modern styles tend to deviate from the semantic structures and notations. They highlight the "intuitive resources" (Carter 181) provided by the dancer's body and mind that aid in the discovery of new meanings that otherwise remain concealed in the semantic system.

Joseph Margolis' theory in which he classifies dance as an "autographic" form of art supports the claim that notation and semantic structures are insufficient in capturing the real essence of communicated meaning. He argues that communication of meaning through dance occurs due to the "natural expressiveness" which is intrinsic to the movements of the dancer. The dancers use their accumulated training and intuition to bring out the hidden expressive qualities of the basic structures. This is indicative of the significance of pragmatic qualities in dance that arise from the dancer's personal, creative use of the body.

Dance also has the ability to express tacit knowledge which cannot be verbalized in regular speech. It can communicate kinesthetically by evoking responses within the dancer's body that resonate in the bodies of the audience members. This demonstrates that dance communication through dance is not entirely dependent upon its semantic structures and communicate meaning even in their absence. The theory of kinesthetics again reinforces the idea that pragmatic factors carry a major brunt of the communication achieved through dance.

An analysis of Tagore's satirical dance-drama *Tasher Desh* reveals the significance of dance in expressing the theme of oppression versus freedom of expression. The coercive forces of oppression become evident in the stiff, mechanical and structured movements of the card-people, while freedom of expression is embodied in the enthusiastic, fluid and uninhibited

movements of the prince. Drawing a comparison between the codified movements of the cards and the intuitive movements of the prince in terms of semantics and pragmatics reveals that pragmatics allows a significantly broader scope for communication of meaning than the limited structures of semantics.

A pragmatic approach to analyzing the "meaning-bearing" (Bannerman 77) capacity of dance remains a largely unexplored domain of study. This thesis emphasizes the significance of pragmatics in understanding dance as an effective system of communication. While semantic structures provide a foundation for the communication of meaning, the pragmatic features play a crucial role in embellishing, enhancing and unveiling multiple layers of meaning that remain concealed in the semantic system.

However, with modern trends in dance eschewing the traditional structures, it has become increasingly difficult to distinguish aesthetic movement from meaningful movement. As dances become more open form, the distinction between meaningful pragmatic movement and regular movement becomes blurred. It is worth investigating whether all movements in dance contribute towards a meaningful transaction and how it is achieved. Future research could centre upon examining if pragmatic movements alone can sustain the communication of meaning through dance. Nevertheless, an analysis of the potential contained in dance to effectively communicate meaning through the lens of pragmatics is essential in eliciting its many intricate implicatures.

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